

Withdrawal and Demoralization

As the war became more controversial, the feelings of Cold War anticommunism and patriotism that had previously inspired soldiers weakened. Personal survival increasingly became more important than the mission to many US soldiers and ARVN allies.

◀◀ BEFORE

Throughout the war, American soldiers listened to rock and roll music and its protest lyrics as an outlet for their frustration.

WAR ANTHEMS

One of the most popular songs among the troops, the 1965 hit "We Gotta Get Out of This Place" by the Animals, was banned from Armed Forces Radio by the South Vietnamese government. With their portable cassette tape players, however, GIs had ready access to songs that voiced **resistance to authority**, including Jimi Hendrix's "Purple Haze," Los Bravos's "Black is Black," the Beatles' "Hey Jude," and John Fogerty's "Fortunate Son."

American troop withdrawals did not happen all at once, but by the end of 1969, the number of troops in Vietnam had decreased by 115,000, and by December 1970, there would be only 280,000 left. In the year in between, a common feeling grew among US servicemen: nobody wanted to be the last to die in Vietnam. The strain of fighting a war with poorly articulated objectives manifested itself in attacks on both officers and noncommissioned officers (NCOs), racial disharmony, and increasingly widespread drug use. Echoing debates at home, many soldiers began to question America's role in Vietnam, their letters home damning the immoral, unlawful, and inglorious war they found themselves still fighting.